Author’s note

Formalities seldom keep their shape when Mr Gibbs is around. I learnt that early on. Our first-ever interview was for a *Sports Illustrated* cover feature, and, as the magazine’s editor, I was after a suitably meaty story. Armed with some tough questions, the plan was to uncover exactly what made this talented but controversial cricketer tick.

It started out as a formal interview all right – me trotting out the big guns on cue – but thanks to Herschelle’s relaxed and open attitude, it soon changed … into a really good chat. That’s his way. For a couple of hours he answered all my questions as honestly as good sense would allow. And that was the beginning of my understanding Herschelle Gibbs a little better.

After spending more time with him over the next six years – and especially during the week we hung out at the 2010 IPL in India – I’ve gained some insights into what makes this cricketer such a popular figure. And you really have to see how Indian fans respond to him to understand the depth of his popularity.

Which, when you think about it, is weird given how equally frustrating it has been to witness his career. This is the part that always puzzled me. How could a guy who has done time for match-fixing, been bust for sucking back some of Antigua’s finest and been to rehab for alcohol addiction still be such a beloved sportsman?

And it’s not like his on-field performances have always counterbalanced his off-field adventures either. There have been many innings in which Hersch appears to have chucked away his wicket. And when we’re up against the Aussies and you need him to score runs, it really is flippin’ annoying.

Why, then, has Herschelle Gibbs remained in the hearts of cricket fans around the world? Why, for example, aside from my sparkling way with